Past continuous or past simple: what Murphy does not tell you

Day 2 · Grammar beyond Murphy

Murphy first
Murphy red, Unit 14 (pages 38–39): **14.1** in class, **14.2** at home. Unit 105 (pages 220–221): **105.1** at home. Unit 98 (pages 206–207): **98.1** on Day 3.
This file adds five things the book does not explain.

1 · Which action came first? Draw it

When I **arrived**, they **were eating**. → they started **before** I came (I interrupted).
When I **arrived**, they **ate**. → they started **after** I came.

Draw two lines on paper: a long line (was eating) and a short stroke (arrived). The long one starts first.

2 · Linking words for a story

as = while: *As I was crossing the street, I saw a fox.*
just as = at the very same moment: *Just as I sat down, the phone rang.*
at that moment · suddenly · then · a few minutes later

Murphy only teaches when and while.

3 · Short form with -ing (same person)

*While **I was walking** home, I saw a fox. = While **walking** home, I saw a fox.*
Only when it is the **same person** in both parts. ✗ While walking home, the fox ran away (the fox was not walking).

4 · Two long actions at the same time

*While Dad **was cooking**, I **was doing** my homework and my sister **was listening** to music.*
Both parts are continuous: nothing interrupts. We do not need **suddenly** here.

5 · The Russian trap

«Когда я шёл домой, я увидел лису.» → *When I **was walking** home, I **saw** a fox.*
«Когда я пришёл, он спал.» → *When I arrived, he **was sleeping**.* «Когда я пришёл, он лёг спать.» → *When I arrived, he **went** to bed.*

Russian shows the difference with the verb form. English shows it with was + -ing.

Practice

Day 2 · Practice 1

What to do: Exercises 1–2 in class, alone, then check. Exercise 3: the class translates aloud, one sentence each.

1 Join the sentences with when or while

1. I was walking in the park. I saw a fox.
2. Dad was cooking. The lights went out.
3. We were swimming. It started to rain.
4. She was reading. She fell asleep.
5. Mom was cooking. I was doing my homework.
6. The phone rang. I was having a shower.
7. They were watching TV. Somebody knocked on the door.
8. He was riding a bike. He fell.

2 Choose the correct form

1. I (saw / was seeing) a snake while I (walked / was walking) in the field.
2. When we (arrived / were arriving), the people (sat / were sitting) and the film (started / was starting).
3. She (cooked / was cooking) when the phone (rang / was ringing).
4. At eight o'clock last night I (did / was doing) my homework.
5. The fox (ran / was running) away when it (saw / was seeing) me.
6. While I (waited / was waiting) for the bus, it (began / was beginning) to rain.
7. He (didn't hear / wasn't hearing) the noise, because he (slept / was sleeping).
8. (Did you see / Were you seeing) the fox when it (crossed / was crossing) the road?

3 Translate into English

1. Когда я шёл домой, я увидел лису.

2. Пока мама готовила, я делал уроки.

3. Когда я пришёл, они ужинали.

4. Он спал, когда зазвонил телефон.

5. Мы гуляли по лесу, когда пошёл дождь.

6. Что ты делал, когда я позвонил?

7. Я не слышал шума: я слушал музыку.

Practice 2

Day 2 · Practice 2

What to do: Alone, then read your sentences aloud.

4 Look and write: what happened?



Write a short story of 6 sentences about the picture. Use *was / were + -ing* for the scene (what the girl was doing) and the past simple for the events. Use when, while or as.

5 Complete the story: past simple or past continuous

Last summer I (1 walk) _____ in the mountains when I (2 see) _____ a rare bird. It (3 sit) _____ on a rock. I (4 take) _____ my phone, but the bird (5 fly) _____ away. While I (6 look) _____ at the sky, a man (7 come) _____. "What (8 you / look) _____ at?" he asked. "A rare bird," I said. "It (9 sit) _____ here when I (10 arrive) _____," he answered, and he laughed.

Answers · Day 2 grammar

For the teacher

1 I saw a fox when I was walking in the park. / While I was walking in the park, I saw a fox. · The lights went out while Dad was cooking. · It started to rain while we were swimming. · She fell asleep while she was reading. · While Mom was cooking, I was doing my homework. · The phone rang while I was having a shower. · Somebody knocked on the door while they were watching TV. · He fell while he was riding a bike.

2 saw, was walking · arrived, were sitting, was starting · was cooking, rang · was doing · ran, saw · was waiting, began · didn't hear, was sleeping · Did you see, was crossing

3 When I was walking home, I saw a fox. · While Mom was cooking, I was doing my homework. · When I arrived, they were having dinner. · He was sleeping when the phone rang. · We were walking in the forest when it started to rain. · What were you doing when I called? · I didn't hear the noise: I was listening to music.

4 Own answers: check was + -ing for the scene and the past simple for the events.

5 was walking · saw · was sitting · took · flew · was looking · came · were you looking · was sitting · arrived